



Ultimate high: Kyle Verreynne celebrates with David Bedingham after hitting the winning runs. AFP

and twos with ease, building momentum without taking risks. The pressure valve was released too early.

To be fair, Cummins was also up against a shifting surface. After two days of dramatic, low-scoring chaos where 28 wickets had fallen, the Lord's pitch suddenly flattened under bright sunshine.

The lack of early turn and bounce blunted Lyon's effectiveness. Both Bavuma and Markram were quick to adjust, playing him comfortably off the back foot, especially through square. With Australia's main spinner neutralised and no reverse swing in sight, Cummins' options dwindled. But the choice to sit back rather than squeeze the batters might still go down as a misstep.

For Bavuma, the moment carried weight beyond the scoreboard. He was the first black South African to score a Test hundred, the first black South African to lead the national team in the format, and now, the

captain who has taken his side to the summit of the World Test Championship.

Most importantly, South Africa has now won nine and lost none of Bavuma's completed Tests as captain — these speak to a leadership quality rooted in clarity, calm, and conviction.

Markram's innings will stand apart as well. On a pair, in the fourth innings of a final, he constructed, countered and ultimately conquered, eventually falling for 136. That this was his third fourth-innings Test century says enough. But context makes it richer: it came not in the calm of a bilateral dead rubber, but on the biggest stage his team has known in nearly three decades.

Yes, it had been 27 years. Since the late Hansie Cronje led the Rainbow Nation to the ICC KnockOut Trophy in Dhaka, South Africa's men's team had won nothing on the world stage. In the 18 global white-ball tournaments since, it reached just one final. That, too, ended in heartbreak — in Barbados last year, when it squandered a position of absolute dominance against India.

The numbers have been well-worn: 12 knockout games, 10 losses, countless post-mortems. The label — chokers — was lazy, but persistent. It became part of how the world described South African men's cricket.

But not anymore.

Pat Cummins threatened to derail its charge with a post-lunch burst on Day 2 — a spell of 4.1-1-4-4 that took him to 300 Test wickets — but the game belonged to Kagiso Rabada, whose nine wickets, including a five-for, across both innings proved decisive. It was a bowler's match, and South Africa's attack held firm when it mattered most.

Yes, its road to the final came through a softer draw — avoiding Australia and England, and playing West Indies, Bangladesh, and New Zealand. But none of that diminishes the quality of their cricket or the resolve they showed when it counted.

Still, this win comes at a strange time for South African Test cricket.

As things stand, the men's team will not host any Tests next summer — the first such break since readmission in 1992. CSA CEO